

Vertigo



The welcome sight of the Hodder huts (photo by Ian Barnes)

Section News

Section Nights

Our September section night and AGM was a little low on numbers – possibly due to the change in date and also the dreaded AGM. Those who attended were provided with the various committee reports and the committee for the next year is confirmed as follows :

Chair – Simon Williamson

Secretary – Carolyn Ellis (also Vertigo editor and Gear custodian)

Treasurer (temporary) – Peter Laurensen (also Photo Comp judge)

Committee members – Eric Duggan (Trip Co-ordinator), Scott Wotring (Social media guru),

Elisha Watson (Reel Rock organiser), Sandy Britain (Summer Rock Co-ordinator), Matt

Pemberton

We'll publish profiles on the committee in the November Vertigo.

The committee reports tabled at the AGM have been included in this newsletter for your information.

November section night – Wednesday 2 November - Back room at the Southern Cross, Abel Smith Street at 6pm

The Director General of DOC, Lou Sanson, is our drawcard for the November section night. Lou will be talking about the sustainability challenges for conservation leaders from Antarctica to the Southern Alps. Lou presented on this topic at the Sustainable Summits conference. Come along and I'm sure the presentation will be of interest and you'll get the opportunity to quiz Lou after his talk.

December Christmas get together – climbing at Baring Head / camping at Catchpool – Saturday 3 December

Similar to the event we held last year, we're planning on heading out to Baring Head for some climbing on Saturday 3 December and then camping overnight at Catchpool. The section will provide drinks and a bbq dinner. You're welcome to just come climb or come camping or both. This is a great opportunity to bring the family along. Drop us an email at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz and let us know if you're coming, how many people and any dietary requirements.

Please don't forget the koha for section night – there'll be an ice bucket at the entry door for that purpose. ☺

Chairs Report October 2016

For those of you who made it to the AGM, thanks for supporting the section. While a quiet affair relative to other section nights it was an enjoyable one. As you can tell from reading this, I was re-elected as Chair for the section. A number of new committee members were also nominated and elected, welcome to Scott, Sandy and Matt. More details on the new committee are on the previous page.

Sadly, it seems that I have to remind some of our members that all those on the section committee, including all our instructors and trip leaders, in fact everyone that helps to organise and provide services to you are volunteers. Though they may have professional qualifications and experience none of them are paid. Yet there have been a number of events where members have treated our volunteers as though they were paid servants. If you aren't satisfied with anything the section provides you are more than welcome to volunteer yourself. More importantly, if you consider that something needs improvement we need you to let us know so it can be addressed. This is particularly important when it comes to concerns about safety. For example, we are well aware that not everyone has the same level of confidence and assessment of risk. As such it is your responsibility to communicate any concerns and take responsibility for your actions before you're over your head. Risk transfer is particularly evident among newer climbers who often allow others or the group to make their decisions for them. When the margin for error is narrow, as it often is in climbing, effective communication is essential.

So, next time you are on a trip, on a course, at a section night, reading an article you like, downloading a trip report consider saying thanks to those that have given their own time and worked hard to provide you with such memorable experiences.

That's it from me this month.

If you have any comments on what you liked or didn't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us @NZACWellington or post a message on our facebook page www.facebook.com/nzacwellington.

Finally: "Just have one more try - it's dead easy to die,
 It's the keeping-on-living that's hard"
 Last Man Walking: Douglas Mawson

Chair: Simon Williamson
NZAC Wellington

For quick access to the section's page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Gear Hire

Don't forget the section has gear for hire : avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, helmets, crampons, probes and PLBs. If you're keen to hire some gear please fill in the form [here](#). Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on its return. The section has purchased a few new transceivers and PLBs and we're looking at adding some new crampons into the gear store soon.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs are covered by the section. If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or know more email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

When?	Where?
13-20 November	Mt Aspiring – led by Simon Williamson

Annual Tukino Rock Climbing Camp

The Tukino Alpine Sports club is again hosting the annual Tukino Rock climbing camp next January (4-8) at Tukino ski field on Mt Ruapehu. The camp is an opportunity for climbers to get together to

climb mountains, rocks, socialise, explore and enjoy the great outdoors. It is also a great opportunity for young people and families to get out and try trad climbing. There are a number of crags well set up with easy access to the top to build anchors and low grade



routes (8-14) with plenty of good pro placements. There are also now plenty of easy bolted routes for those wanting to experience alpine rock cragging!

Getting there

The camp is located at the Tukino Alpine Sports Club Lodge, which is on the eastern slopes of Mount Ruapehu. To get right up to the lodge you will need a 4WD. There is a 2WD carpark on the road up to the lodge and the drive from the 2WD carpark to lodge is about 10 minutes. This makes it a sizeable walk between them. If you do not have a 4WD, it is recommended that you get in touch with the Lodge Manager to see if someone with a 4WD can drive down and pick

you up from the 2WD carpark. Some 2WD vehicles did make it right up to the lodge, but this puts your car at risk.

Accommodation

The lodge has 6 bedrooms with differing numbers of bunks in each one. You will need to bring a sleeping bag, but pillows are provided (you may wish to bring your own pillow slip). The lodge has Wifi (for a fee), hot water and excellent cooking facilities. Although the camp runs for nearly an entire week, feel free to come for only part of the camp.

Food

Food is included in the accommodation fee. If you have registered as Gluten Free/Vegetarian etc, this will be provided for. There will be a cooking roster and everyone will take turns cooking breakfast/lunch/dinner for the group based on set recipes. There is definitely enough food for three square meals a day. However, if you want alcohol/chocolate/other treats, you will have to bring that yourself.

Climbing

There are mainly trad routes on Ruapehu, with some bolted/mixed routes. There are [143 routes](#) on the climbNZ database with heaps of potential for first ascents of both trad and bolted lines (bring your drill and bolts with you!).

No gear is provided by the camp, so bring as much gear as you can. If you have lots of gear at home, it would be great if you could bring extra gear with a mind to sharing it with other people. If you don't have much gear, you have a few options. Ideally before the camp you would enquire around friends/family and see if anyone has gear you can borrow. Otherwise at the camp itself you can ask around and try to buddy up with someone with more gear so that you can do as much climbing as possible.

The climbing aspect of the camp is not organised, so feel free to do as much or as little as you like. At the beginning of each day people tend to discuss where they want to go and what they want to do.

Some of the crags are quite far away from the lodge, so bring good tramping shoes.

Other mountain activities

There are various things to explore on the mountain. There is an old plane wreckage and allegedly even ice caves (yet to be located). Quite a few people enjoy a walk up to the summit, so bring an ice-axe and crampons if that sounds like you.

Getting away

The last day of the camp involves cleaning up the lodge. There is a lot of rubbish to take away. If you leave before the last day of the camp, please take some sacks of rubbish down with you and give them to the local tip.

Things to bring

- Climbing helmet
- Climbing shoes

- Tramping shoes
- Trad gear
- Harness
- Rope
- Lunch box
- Warm clothes (it can get cold waiting to climb)
- Sun protection
- Wet weather gear
- Sleeping bag
- Optional: card games/board games, treats, books etc

Cost

(NZAC members): \$37.50 per night for Adults and \$18.75 for under 18years.

To book your place

[Tukino](#) (select NZAC Events at Tukino)

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ are running their River Safety course on Sunday 4 November. The venue will be advised closer to the time but is likely to be in the Hutt Valley. The course costs \$50. This day-long course starts with understanding river dynamics and hazards and moves on to how to evaluate sites for safe crossing, methods of crossing, preparing clothing and equipment for a crossing, managing a group crossing, pack floating and how to self-rescue if swept away.

The first half of the course is theory and "dry" practice drills. After lunch (BYO) the course moves onto the river bed for progressively "wetter" putting the morning's learning into practice.

The course is designed for hikers, climbers and hunters so if you're planning on heading into the hills and you're keen to deal with rivers safely this course is perfect. To register for the course click [here](#).

In the new year OTNZ will be running a navigation course (one evening of theory and one field day) on 12 March, introductory bushcraft course (24-26 March), intermediate bushcraft course (24-26 February) and advanced bushcraft course (6-7 May). Their website will be updated soon so if you're keen on any of these courses keep an eye on <http://www.outdoortraining.nz/courses/courses.php> for details.

NZAC Wellington Section Annual Committee Reports

CHAIR'S REPORT 2016

Simon Williamson



Once again, meeting new and interesting people, tying on to the end of a rope and hanging over a cliff has resulted in more great friendships, amazing (and sometimes unbelievable) stories of adventure told around campfires, in huts and in bivvys. So it is that we have had yet another great year of great courses, amazing trips and outstanding events.

Our membership continues to grow as does attendance at our section nights. Once again our rock and alpine courses were sold out. Feedback rated the quality, professionalism and value for money consistently high for all participants without exception! There have also been a growing number of climbing trips, many of which you will have read about in Vertigo. The Banff Mountain Film Festival sold out again this year and we added Reel Rock which provided a truly outstanding selection of climbing films. Other activities included our instructor development, outdoor first aid and avalanche awareness courses for our instructors. We will continue to subsidise section trips and work on attracting a range of interesting and informative speakers and other activities for you to choose from. All this comes to you thanks to a small group of dedicated volunteer fellow climbers known as the Wellington Section Committee. So, if you have been on a course, enjoyed a great trip and or been entertained at a section night, not to mention benefited from access to cheap gear rental, free PLB loan or local store discounts etc, it is because I've had a devoted group of committee members working to make this happen. If you see any of them around, don't be afraid to say thanks, I'm sure they would appreciate it. Better still, ask not what your committee can do for you but what you can do for your committee and help make the Wellington section even better.

Sustainable Summits

This year I had the opportunity to attend the Sustainable Summits conference. An international gathering of outdoor professionals and organisations discussing and debating a wide variety of issues facing the environment we play in and the communities that use that environment. It was an equally exciting and depressing event. Exciting because it highlighted the diverse nature of opportunities the alpine environment offers an incredibly wider variety of users. Depressing because it is under threat from poor coordination among these users and rapid environmental degradation due to climate change and overuse. DoC has a major challenge which would be helped if those working and playing in the outdoor sector made more of an effort to work

together rather than compete or ignore each other. In a world of increasing opportunities for outdoor recreation, providers such as the NZAC, tramping clubs, commercial operators and government need to stop trampling each other and collaborate before we end up trampling the environment we do dearly enjoy and need to protect.



What you're thinking

In last year's Chair's report I asked what you thought we should be doing and if what we are doing is meeting your needs. The deafening silence of the response may mean that you are all very happy with the way things are going, don't care and / or didn't read the report. But the offer still stands. If you have any thoughts or suggestion on other things we could do or do better I would be pleased to hear from you.

Big thanks

As always a big thanks to our active and committed committee members and other helpers without whom my job would be impossible and you wouldn't have a section to belong to. Some of our committee has stepped down this year. Aviette, our Banffmeister, avalanche and snow craft instructor has done a sterling job over the past few years running Banff and, thankfully, has committed to carrying on managing Banff and teaching snow craft though she will no longer attend committee meetings. Gina has also stepped down after doing an awesome job getting Reel Rock up and running. We hope to get her back to help with Reel Rock 12 next year. The pull of home was strong for Mark Johnston so he's now our representative back in South Africa and is enjoying being close to some amazing rock climbing. Carolyn, who is thankfully not stepping down has done an even more awesome job as Vertigo editor, secretary, assistant alpine instructor and picking up the banking and finance management. Nish did a great job with snowcraft course bookings, section night bookings, and assistant alpine instructor and Elisha as Summer Rock coordinator, Twitter and Facebookmeister. Peter has nailed the section night management and photo comp this year while Eric has set up and led some particularly

memorable trips. Thanks also to those of you who have helped to lighten the load including all our rock and winter snow craft instructors. Also, Jade was a star sorting out Summer Rock logistics! With special mention and welcome to Sandy who has joined the section as our new summer rock lead instructor and one of our senior snow craft instructors. We are in need of someone to pick up the finance portfolio so if you know what a spreadsheet is or better still can read a bank statement we would love to hear from you.

All the best for the summer climbing season

Vertigo and Gear Report

Carolyn Ellis

It's been another great year for Vertigo with some bumper issues providing reading fodder for section members and others far and wide. There hasn't been a strict schedule in the past for submitting items for inclusion – the newsletter is published during the last week of the month so generally I need items the week before that (the third week of a month). I'm always on the hunt for your trip reports and photos and it's important to note that your trips don't need to be of the "highly technical / difficult / couldn't possibly do that" ilk.

Our membership ranges from those who are embarking on their first grade 1 alpine climbs through to the Grand Traverse / first ascent types so trip reports at any level are always of interest.

In addition, if there's an event coming up that you'd like to be advertised or you simply have a point of view you'd like to express or a technique or idea to share with others feel free to send them through.

On the gear side of things, we're getting better at having a workable process in place for section members to hire gear and borrow PLBs. I'll be updating our page on the national NZAC website soon so you'll be able to find the link to request gear easily. In the meantime, I've been including it in Vertigo recently. It's a good idea to give a bit of prior warning when you want to get your hands on gear. Those requests for gear needed on the following day are hard to fill at times. We've invested in new PLBs and transceivers this year and we're adding some new items into our gear store in the next little while – new crampons, hammers, etc - I'll make sure I advertise what's new in Vertigo.

Trips Report

Eric Duggan

There have been 6 section trips held this year since January.

January - Tukino climbing Camp

The Wellington Section helped Tukino Alpine Sports Club run the annual Tukino summer climbing camp based at TASC lodge. A number of new areas were developed over the 5 days of the camp.



April - Tukino Rock Climbing

A weekend rock climbing at Tukino. A few children came on this trip as well.

April - Mt Somers Rock Climbing

3 days climbing excellent trad lines at Mt Somers.

June - Te Ao Whekere

A successful ascent of Te Ao Whekere in the seaward Kaikouras.

July - Tukino North Island Ice Climbing Meet

The Wellington section organised the North Island Ice Climbing Meet based at TASC lodge. Relatively thin ice conditions but good weather (despite the forecast) and ascents of Bowl Wobbler, Irish Ice Express, and Margarets Leap.

October - Tapuae-o-Uenuku

A 3 day trip to attempt to climb Tapuae-o-Uenuku and Alarm in the Inland Kaikoura Range.

Coming Up

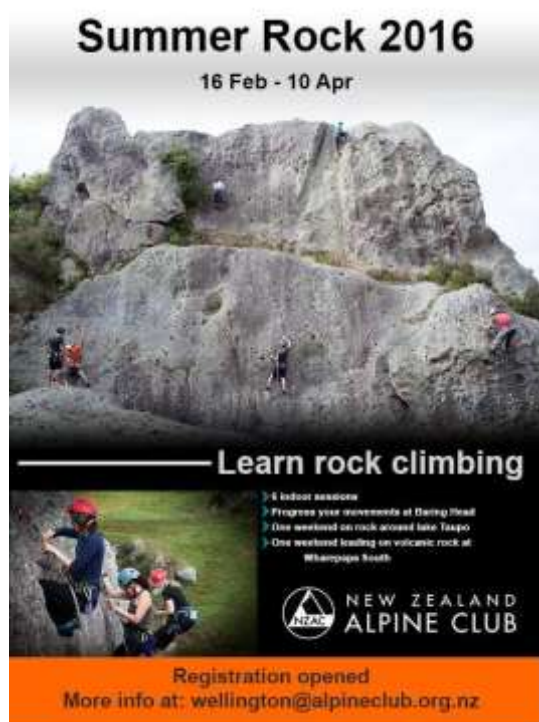
Labour Weekend – 10 people are heading to Paynes Ford for rock climbing and a similar number are off to Mt Hopeless for a spot of alpine climbing

Summer Rock

Gina Butson

Once again, Summer Rock was fully subscribed this year. And, once again, the 12 students on the course were fun, enthusiastic and, in many cases, already strong climbers. While Summer Rock remains open to climbers of all levels (including those who have never before set foot in a climbing gym), we are seeing an increasing trend in Summer Rock participants who are already

proficient in the art of top-roping or bouldering in the gym, but who want to learn how to transition to the great outdoors. The course does that through six mid-week gym sessions and three weekends away on real rock. This year saw a return to Ferg's for the indoor sessions, and back to Baring Head, Kinloch, and Wharepapa for the outdoor sessions.



A big thanks to all the Summer Rock instructors who give up evenings and weekends to share their skills and enthusiasm for climbing. A sure sign of the success of Summer Rock is that most of the instructors have completed the course themselves. This year many of the instructors were Summer Rock 2015 graduates – this is invaluable in demonstrating to the current students just how much they can improve in a year. A special

thanks to Robin Maxwell for, once again, ensuring that everyone is well fed (or should that be 'over fed'?) and to Jade Cincotta for all the behind-the-scenes organising. And an extra special thanks to Scott Taylor who has been chief instructor on Summer Rock for the past several years but who, sadly, is leaving us to move to sunnier, rockier Nelson. Scott is an amazing font of knowledge, skill, humour and patience. You may not think it to look at him, but Scott moves like a ballerina on the rock, and many a Wellington climber can thank Scott for his insistence on footwork. Although Scott will be greatly missed and leaves big rubber-soled shoes to fill, we are very lucky that Sandy Britain has turned up in Wellington to take over as chief instructor of Summer Rock. We look forward to working with Sandy next year and to seeing all our Summer Rock 2016 graduates at the gym and crag (and maybe as Summer Rock 2017 instructors).

Reel Rock

Gina Butson

This year the Section decided to screen Reel Rock at the cinema for the first time (at last year's AGM we showed some Reel Rock films on the small screen). Like the Banff film festival, Reel Rock is a collection of the year's best outdoor sports films and has screenings around the world. Unlike Banff, the focus of Reel Rock is squarely on climbing – climbing in all its many, often crazy, sometimes hilarious, forms. As this was the first time we'd screened the films, we kept it more low key than the annual Banff event: we opted for one session only and, given the proximity to the Section's photo comp, decided to give our generous sponsors a break and ran the night without speeches and giveaways. Audience reaction and feedback indicated that the night was a success.

Reel Rock Financials		
	Credit	Debit
Ticket sales (178 tickets) 82 x Adult (\$21) 56 x NZAC discount (\$19) 28 x Student (\$19) 12 x Child (\$14)	\$3486	
Cinema hire (Paramount)		\$1000
Reel Rock licence fee		\$1447.78 (\$1000USD)
Total	\$1,038.22	

Update on Social Media

Elisha Watson

Social media is a key tool used by the Wellington Section to keep in touch with its members. The Wellington Section Facebook page has 530 people following it. 'Event' pages are created and posted on the Facebook page, allowing members to be reminded before the event and follow updates. Facebook was particularly helpful with promoting Reel Rock, however the Reel Rock event was mysteriously deleted on the day of the screening itself, which was a bit of a debacle.

Facebook is also a great way to share photos of trips that our members have been on, and was also used this year to showcase the winners of the Wellington Section photography competition.

Social media has also provided us with a great way of keeping track of what other outdoor groups are getting up to and allows us to connect with them.

BANFF Report

Aviette Musin

This year we, once again, had four sell out sessions for Banff. One of the highlights was having director Simon Lucas, introduce his film "Paddle for the North".



Thank you to everyone who came to the Paramount to enjoy the films. We sold 1,585 tickets across the four screenings. This is currently our only fund raiser. The funds help to bring in some of the section night speakers and subsidise some of the climbing trips as well as maintain and replace gear for courses.

Annual photo competition report

Peter Laurenson

As in 2015, Peter Laurenson and Nigel Roberts co-judged the entries for the annual Wellington Section photo competition and presented their findings at the September section night. Once again the standard of entries varied, but some excellent entries were received, some of which went on to do well at the national competition.

The number of entries increased by 26%. The table below compares 2016 to last year across the seven categories. Only 20 or so turned up for the section night, including only one of the category winners, which was a shame, but those that did attend found it useful.

NZAC Wellington

entries	2015	2016	Change
Alpine General	28	28	0%
Alpine Activity	13	19	46%
Alpine Nature	12	19	58%
Rock climbing	11	8	-27%
Mountain Culture	5	11	120%
Humour	4	12	200%
Kids	13	11	-15%
	86	108	26%



Winning photo of the Wellington Section photo comp 2016 - by Iain Burgon

Section nights report 2015/16

Peter Laurenson

In the past 12 months section nights have been held, usually on the first Wednesday each month, at the Southern Cross Tavern from 6pm. No section nights were held in January due to the Christmas break and June due to the Banff Mountain Film Festival.

A range of speakers presented trips and other subjects related to climbing such as weather, mapping, yoga/fitness and outdoor gear. Section nights also featured movies, the annual photo competition judging and the AGM.

Turnouts vary from between about 20 and 60. The current venue struggles at the higher end and there are some noise issues, which mean that alternative venues are currently under consideration.

Section nights are confirmed for October and November 2016. The table below shows details of each section night since September 2015.

Section night	Subject(s)	Speaker(s)
Sep-15	Valley Uprising movie night	
Oct-15	1. Deciding to Survive -Risk management and decision making in the mountains 2. Hanging on to Tukino - The Tukino Alpine Sports Club	1. Rohan Light, international risk taker, organisational strategist and student of 'decision science' 2. Don French and Mark Henson
Nov-15	Skiing the long white cloud – a journey the length of the Southern Alps	Erik Bradshaw
Dec-15	AGM and movie night	Committee
Jan-16	No section night	Christmas break
Feb-16	Reel rock 10 movie night	
Mar-16	Three years in the NZ Alpine Team - alpine rock climbing in the Darrans and in Chamonix, ice climbing in the Canadian Rockies, mountaineering in the Southern Alps and the team's upcoming expedition to Peru.	Jaz Morris
Apr-16	1. Weather 2. The role of Walking Access and information about their mapping service.	1. Leigh Matheson Met Service 2. Ric Cullinane Walking Access
May-16	Various ascents in the European Alps, mainly around Chamonix. He has made seven trips to the	Daniel Joll

	Alps (three winter and four summer), with around 60 successful ascents including classics like the north faces of the Eiger, the Grandes Jorasses and the Dru.	
Jun-16	No section night due to Bamff	
Jul-16	The science behind and benefits of yoga and functional movement training. Megan and Carl took us through some practical assessments of balance, body awareness and alignment, strength and range of motion. Megan and Carl also gave away passes to attend a free class at HealthFit.	Megan Sety and Carl Hammington HealthFit Collective
Aug-16	Earth Sea Sky experiences	David Ellis Earth Sea Sky
Sep-16	Annual Photo Competition judging night	Peter Laurensen and Nigel Roberts
Oct-16	AGM agenda plus short movies	Committee
Nov-16	Antarctica to the Southern Alps - Sustainability Challenges for Conservation Leaders	Lou Sanson DOC Director General & previous CEO Antarctica NZ
Dec-16	TBC – probably climbing at Baring Head, camping at Catchpool on 10 December	
Jan-17	No section night	Christmas break
Feb-17	TBC	TBC
Mar-17	“Twin summits - highs and lows of a bifurcated climbing career” Penny will talk a bit about climbing in the 70s and 80s (as a young thing) in NZ, USA and the Himalayas and then returning to climbing in the 2000s after a break tending career and family. Recent highs and lows are more in the “mild things” category - Aspiring, Cook, Olivines, trekking in Nepal, skiing in Norway and rafting the Grand Canyon (this is the “low” since we went down the canyon). Penny will finish up with a brief picture of her view of where NZAC is at the moment and where it’s going, particularly as a result of the current strategic planning process.	Penny Brothers NZAC President

Did you know?

As a result of some recent conversations with some section members it appears that there's a lack of awareness of some of the discounts you're eligible for as section members.

Have you got an FMC membership card? They look like this :



As an Alpine Club member, you're eligible to also be a member of the FMC. That membership means you can get an adult annual back-country hut pass for just over \$85 – a heck of a lot easier than mucking around with purchasing hut tickets and quite a bargain for those of us who are out in the hills often. You can also get 15% off Easy Change and Saver Change fares on the Interislander. Now, you may have opted out of FMC membership. If you haven't received the FMC bulletin with any of your Climber magazines and you'd like to opt in you'll need to contact [Margaret](#) at National Office. If you have family membership you're all eligible to hold an FMC membership card and get the discounts – again you'll need to let Margaret know. If you've misplaced your FMC card, Margaret can also help you with a replacement card. You need to show this card when you purchase your bank-country hut pass from DOC.

Information on all of the discounts available to you can be found on the NZAC website [here](#). There are discounts for all sorts of things including gear and clothing retailers, insurance,

Trip Reports

Club trip to Tapuae-o-Uenuku

Weekend of September 7 - 9, 2016

Scribe : Peter Sandston

By Thursday afternoon I was frazzled, broke and short of favours. My partner and I had done the Snowcraft 1 Intro course a few weeks earlier and then a couple of weeks after the course we went to watch Reel Rock at the Paramount. Immediately overcome with a disdain for all things safe and comfortable, I replied to the mysterious Ian Barnes to say I was keen for the Tapuae-o-Uenuku trip. I don't have the gear, I don't have the leave, I don't know what it involves, but get-me-out-of-the-city let's go climb a mountain. With an email from Ian, a signed form and a ferry planned for Thursday, I was in.

Enthusiasm for the outdoors? 8. Alpine climbing experience? 1. Tent? No. Cooker and fuel for 5 days?! No. Boots? No. Rainproof clothing? No. I was immediately feeling unprepared. Needless to say, the next few days were a blur of over-stretched lunchtimes and weary credit card transactions. But with all five of the gloves ticked off the gear list and a last minute delivery of rainproof pants, I was feeling more like a mountaineer. I took up a post in the Interislander waiting room to spot fit people with ice axes, and sure enough in came Ian and Ryan. Ryan had been with me on the Snowcraft course and I knew was good for a laugh because he had just pre-hike hiked to the ferry from Aro Valley in Converse All-stars, which were also his approach shoes. Ian let on that of the 9 people signed-up, 4 were the victim of weather-forecast related illnesses and general blowouts, but not to worry! We were on our way!

We picked up the people mover in Picton and drove the couple hours to the Hodder bridge, parked up, set camp and immediately went to sleep. We woke to a beautiful Friday morning on the riverbank of the Hodder, a cool spring dew and the sparkling river stretched before us. It was

exactly what I needed to flush office life out of my mind. Excited, we made breakfast (new cooker, billy and spoon; all great) and donned our approach shoes for the 80+ river crossings we were expecting that day. The landowner stopped by to confirm that the farm-track section of the walk was off limits due to lambing, so we'd be walking the whole way up to the Hodder Huts in the river bed. We were expecting Simon and



Hodder

Carolyn to meet us at the huts that night, and so with the enthusiasm of climbers newly released from the city, we set off.

The walk up the river was rough enough to kick us into adventure mode but simple enough to navigate without trouble. The river wanders lazily from side to side of the valley, meaning that every 100m or so you're back in the water. The steady routine of route picking between river rocks followed by knee deep ice bathing was actually pretty entertaining and the day passed without incident; just a happy day of classic hiking in good weather with good company.

As always the first sight of the Hodder Huts was a very welcome one, and with one last steep shingle ascent up out of the river we were there. Keen to frame our excitement for the coming day, Ryan and I trekked out to have a look at the start of the Staircase Stream route and hopefully the summit up above us.

Simon and Carolyn arrived with uncertain predictions of the weather for our summit attempt the next day, so we agreed to a 5am wakeup the next morning. An Alpine Start! Things were getting serious. Next morning, Simon shows up at the door- 4:30am. We then made a completely un-biased technical assessment of the weather conditions from our bunks and decided that it was, indeed, too windy for this time of the morning.



Sunrise at the Hodder huts



7am and it was on. The wind had died down as per request and there was even a hint of sunshine in the valley. With appropriate gear rationed around and our packs lightened, we set off up the valley to do what we'd come here to do. The snowline was still far above us so the first half of our ascent at least was on steep

loose shingle, but with sturdy (and dry) boots dutifully carried in the day before the going was good.



Making some schoolboy errors with my layers, I somehow managed to take clothes off as we got colder and higher - next time I'll try for the other way around. We followed the track from Staircase stream up to a beautiful alpine waterfall to stop for snacks and route planning. Ryan and Simon took the lead and we continued up the steep loose shingle and over some rock formations that had us scrambling up a ridge above the waterfall. With large sharp flakes of scree crumbling and releasing onto our hapless comrades below, we decided to name our innovative new route the 'Williamson Rockfall' in honour of our intrepid leader.

Completing the ridge we sidled into a basin above the waterfall, north-west and below the summit. At about 1900m we encountered our first snow and pressed on (new boots: also great) with the snow allowing for full forefoot purchase without any slide, and steady

climbing. The alpine zone quickly welcomed us into its reality with periodic blasts of sand-like hail that caught us in the open, reminding us of the forecast we'd been determined to forget. Pressing on up the north-west aspect with the wind and occasional sandstorm of ice at our backs, we made good progress.

Crampons fitted and axes in hand, we made our final push for the ridge. As a newbie to the alpine climbing world, I was learning something with every step and absolutely loving the adventure. Had the wind been in my face, rather than at my back, it probably would have been a different story, but still. Slow and steady got us up the last icy chute with Simon's lead



giving us the confidence to keep pushing on. We made it to a corniced ridge to the West of the Summit and were pinned down by the most determined wind I have ever experienced. Hanging in there with jackets flapping their way through Mach 1, we looked up to see 'the summit' which was all of 100m away! We could make that!



Summit in the murk in the background

Then the cloud ominously cleared to show us the real-deal, actual summit. It was 100m above us and definitely achievable for us in better conditions, but absolutely scary right now. Periodic hail showers, biblical wind and poor visibility were fraying the nerves of the group and with heavy hearts we made the call to end our attempt at the summit there.

Making our first real descent on steep icy snow in crampons tested the nerves to start with, but with Simon showing us the way we settled into an easy controlled walk back down the mountain. It was amazing how quickly the conditions settled as we descended from the ridge, and with sun shining and wind abating the group's morale returned. Deep pockets of windblown spring powder then took the icy edge out of the hike down and we giant-stepped through the valleys and back down to lunch, and eventually home to the Huts.



Lunch stop

Happy with our adventure, on Sunday we hiked out back down through the river, encountering everything from mountain mist, to deep, hard hail and rain to glorious sunshine. We finished back at the car with the sun shining and then beers over pizza back in Picton. It was the perfect end to our first attempt at a decent mountain. We all agreed that at some point, we'd be back.

Notices

Inspiring Explorers Expedition 2017

Applications are now open for the Antarctic Heritage Trust's Inspiring Explorers Expedition 2017.

This is an opportunity of a lifetime for up to four young New Zealanders to participate in a heavily sponsored expedition to the Antarctic Peninsula in February 2017. Weather and conditions permitting, the team will attempt a guided ascent of Mt Scott.

The expedition aims to encourage young people both to explore the physical world to educate and inspire them, as well as to challenge those participating to inspire others to explore.

More information and applications are at <https://www.nzaht.org/pages/inspiring-explorers-2017>

Book Launch Wellington 10 November - Outdoor Appetite

Guest Speaker: Dr John McKinnon, first Doctor at the Khunde Hospital and Nepal tourism company owner - Footprints

In association with the Himalayan Trust, Bivouac Outdoor would like to invite you to come to their Wellington store for the launch of 'Outdoor Appetite', a cookbook for anyone who loves healthy, wholesome and delicious food.

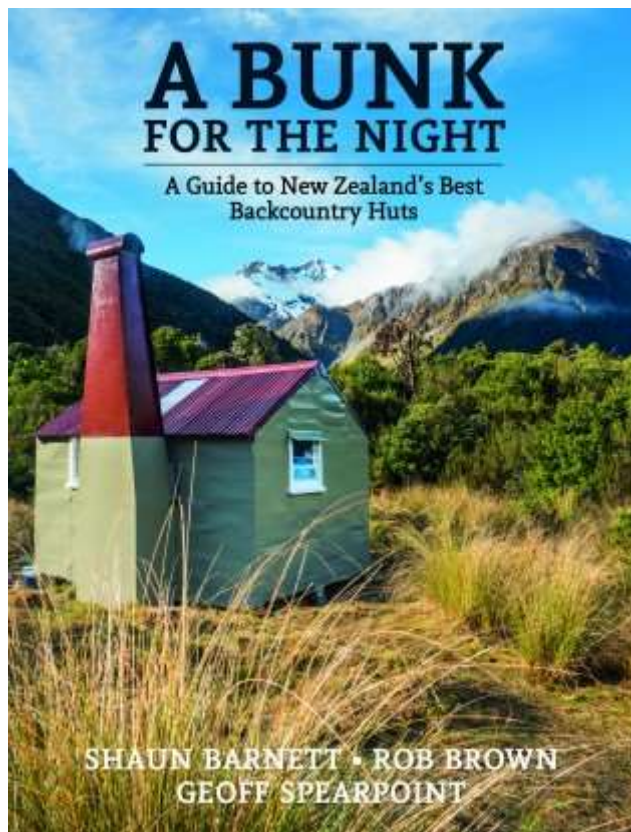


Mouth-watering photography by Lindsay Keats complements the wide range of tried and true recipes, which included contributions from the family of Sir Edmund Hillary, actress Joanna Lumley, Adventure Consultant's Guy Cotter and many more. All proceeds from the sale of Outdoor Appetite will go to support the work of the Himalayan Trust in Nepal and fund rebuilding schools and training teachers.

See event calendar for full event details as well as a link to purchase this title if you are unable to attend the event: https://alpineclub.org.nz/single-event/?event_id=2364839

New book available – A Bunk for the night

A Bunk for the Night offers a guide to over 200 of the best of these huts to visit. This inspirational book has been written by Shaun Barnett, Rob Brown and Geoff Spearpoint, the authors of the seminal, best-selling history of New Zealand's backcountry huts [Shelter from the Storm](#). NZAC members can purchase this book for \$40 [here](#).



NZAC member discounted rates at DOC huts

A reminder to members that you will need to have your ACTIVE NZAC membership card with you when paying hut fees at DOC offices to obtain discounted rates. They have no way to check your membership is active and will likely insist on seeing your card to give you member rates. NZAC won't be able to refund overpayments, so it is important to have your member card on you at the time of payment.

NZAC 2017 Climbing Camp

The Otago Section will be hosting the 2017 climbing camp that will be from Saturday 4th to Saturday 11th February. The Camp will be based at the Top Forks Hut in the Wilkin Valley. As it is a 12 hour walk into the Top Forks hut it is proposed that people attending the camp travel by helicopter from Makarora.

Top Forks hut is in a stunning alpine environment and there are several peaks within striking distance of the hut, many of them grade 1 climbs. Campers are expected to be self-contained with their own tent, cooking equipment, fuel and food. We will have access to the hut but not exclusive use. We will be providing some basic communal facilities such as a tarp shelter, dish-washing facilities, toilet tent, thermos and a mountain radio.

We will limit the number of people attending the camp to 40 so early registration is recommended. You can obtain additional information and a registration form from the NZAC website. There will be a modest registration fee and you are expected to pay for your helicopter or jet boat travel to and from the camp. Budget on \$170 each way to/from Top Forks for the helicopter or \$110 each way for jet boat access via Kerin Forks Hut. Note: Top Forks is still a 6 hr walk from Kerin Forks. An option is to fly in and jet boat out.

The camp is suitable for climbers of all levels of experience but you must be an Alpine club member to attend. If you do not have a climbing partner at the camp we will arrange for you to team up with other climbers.

If you require additional information contact Keith Moffat Ph 03 473-8903 Mob 0276644037 or e-mail Moffat.k172@gmail.com

Hand-Printed Limited Edition Freda du Faur Poems

Sarah M. Smith, Book Arts Printer from Dartmouth College, Hanover, New Hampshire, was the 2016 Printer in Residence at Otakou Press, University of Otago. Sarah hand-printed a volume of poetry by poet Rhian Gallagher on the climbing activities of Freda Du Faur; this wonderful production has been illustrated by print maker Lynn Taylor.

Limited edition: 100 copies for sale. Cost \$120.00 (incl GST)

To arrange purchase, email [Donald Kerr](mailto:Donald.Kerr@otago.ac.nz) at Special Collections, University of Otago.

Wellington Section 2016 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer (Acting)	Peter Laurensen	
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Elisha Watson	
	Matt Pemberton	
	Sandy Britain	
	Scott Wotring	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893

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* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



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